

RURAL ROADS

■ By Shankkar Aiyar

Mahabir Mahto, who is as old as independent India, used to have a unique qualification among his village folk. He was among the three people in his 100-home village to have seen a bus. Called Panchpahia, which ironically means five wheels, the village drove into the 20th century in 2004, when it was connected to the rural road network under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY). Mahto says that thanks to the roads, the village—located 16 km from Manoharpur in the Naxal-infested West Singhbhum district of Jharkhand—is now connected to the world. Indeed, when private operators stopped picking up passengers from Panchpahia on the

Manoharpur-Rourkela service, villagers balked at stepping into those six-wheelers. Now they travel two hours to sell vegetables and fruits in Rourkela. They want frequent services, better connectivity with other districts and longer halts at their village. It is a story that is echoed across many of India's 6,00,000 villages where modern life has changed, nay, arrived at humble homes.

PMGSY wasn't born out of intellectual discussions or policy prattle. Sometime in October 1999, Nitin Gadkari, the BJP leader in Maharashtra—who blazed new trails with his road and flyover connectivity programme in the state—called on the then prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. The exact

Streets of DESIRE

For decades, thousands of India's villages were cut off till Atal Bihari Vajpayee ordained connectivity. The Prime Minister's Gram Sadak Yojana has connected Bharat to India and integrated its villages with the booming economy.

PANKAJ TIWARI

RURAL CONNECT: The road from Fanda to Lela Khedi, Madhya Pradesh

